Policy & Strategy Lab

Learning Outcomes and Competency Framework

Stage 2 of 12 · Version 0.1 · Draft for review · 10 November 2026

Item	Detail
Document	Learning Outcomes and Competency Framework (Course Bible, item 02)
Status	Draft. Rests on provisional decisions DL-015 to DL-017; see Section 2
Builds on	Course Concept Note v0.2; decision log DL-001 to DL-020
Feeds	Stage 3 (which tools the library must supply), Stage 4 (curriculum), Stage 6 (workbooks), Stage 8 (rubrics)

Contents

- Summary
- 1. What this framework does
- 2. Decisions it rests on
- 3. Programme learning outcomes
- 4. Workbooks and artefacts referred to
- 5. The competency framework
- 6. Day-by-day outcome map
- 7. Skill progression
- 8. Assessment alignment
- 9. Cross-cutting professional skills and responsible AI
- 10. Entry and exit diagnostic
- 11. Analyst Development Tracker
- 12. Completion standard (deferred)
- 13. Gap audit and next steps
- Annex. Sources and verification

Summary

This document sets out what a participant must be able to do by the end of the Lab, how anyone would know, and where each ability is taught, practised and assessed. It works in five layers:

1. **Ten programme outcomes**: what a graduate can do.
2. **Ten competency domains**: the areas of competence, A to J.
3. **Fifty competencies**: specific abilities, each with an ID (A1, A2 and so on) that workbooks, feedback and rubrics will use.
4. **Performance indicators**: what an assessor observes when a participant meets the Working level, which is the working assumption for completion.
5. **Evidence and assessment**: the artefact that shows the competency and the assessment component in which it counts.

Four checks were run on the framework. Every outcome is taught on at least one named day. Every outcome is assessed in at least two components, at least one of them individual. Every competency has an artefact that shows it. Every domain is assessed formatively before it is assessed summatively. The last check exposed one weakness: the Week 4 domains (option appraisal and delivery design) get only one formative check before the final assessment. Section 13 proposes a fix.

Decision 5 (no primary research) changes the evidence domain. Interviewing has been removed. Qualitative evidence now comes from published sources such as social audit reports, CAG findings, parliamentary committee testimony and field studies, and the Case Approval Form asks for one such source before a case is approved.

1. What this framework does

The framework follows the principle of constructive alignment: what participants are meant to learn, what they do in sessions and what is assessed should be the same things, described in the same terms. Most courses that fail do so because these three drift apart. The session teaches one thing, the workbook asks for another and the rubric rewards a third.

Four groups use the framework:

User	Use
Course director	Checks that every day and every workbook earns its place
Instructor	Points feedback at a specific competency ID rather than writing general comments
Participants	Self-assess against a plain-language version in Workbook 1
Stage 8 (assessment)	Builds rubrics from the domain descriptors in Section 5

Outcomes are written with observable verbs. Each one ends in something a participant produces: a statement, a tree, a matrix, a memo, a deck or an answer under questioning. Verbs such as "understand", "appreciate" and "be aware of" are not used, because nobody can observe them.

2. Decisions it rests on

Decision	Outcome	Effect on this framework
1. Audience (DL-015)	Final-year UG, PG and early-career professionals; provisional	Outcomes are pitched at application and analysis, with evaluation and creation reserved for the capstone. No prior consulting or statistics assumed
2. Anchor-tool rule (DL-016)	Provisional; review at Stage 4	Each competency is tied to one anchor tool. If the rule is rejected, the competencies still hold but the day mapping changes
3. Named client (DL-017)	Provisional; the client is a role, never contacted	Competency A4 and Outcome 1 depend on it. If dropped, A4 would become "identifies who could act"
4. Completion standard (DL-018)	Deferred to Stage 8	Indicators are written at the Working level so that any threshold chosen later can be applied
5. Primary research (DL-019)	None	Interview design removed; E5 rewritten around published qualitative evidence; ethics competency J5 simplified
6. Capstone (DL-020)	Approved	Outcomes 8 to 10 assessed mainly through the report, presentation and defence

3. Programme learning outcomes

By the end of the programme, a participant who meets the completion standard will be able to:

#	Outcome	Cognitive level	Main domain
1	**Frame.** Convert a broad public concern into a decision-focused problem statement that names the affected population, place, responsible institution, decision-making role, decision and measure of success	Analyse, create	A
2	**Structure.** Build a mutually exclusive, collectively exhaustive issue or hypothesis tree to three levels, and use it to decide what to analyse and what to leave out	Analyse	B
3	**Diagnose.** Distinguish symptoms, proximate causes and structural causes, and represent at least one feedback relationship that sustains the problem	Analyse	C
4	**Situate.** Map the jurisdiction, funding, delivery chain and actors that shape the problem, including those with an interest but no voice	Analyse	D
5	**Hypothesise.** State falsifiable hypotheses, specify what evidence would weaken each one, and keep a register of how each fares	Create, evaluate	F
6	**Investigate.** Locate, assess and triangulate published Indian administrative, survey, audit and research evidence, recording an explicit reliability judgement for each source	Evaluate	E
7	**Synthesise.** Reduce findings to a governing message using the Pyramid Principle, keeping facts, inferences and assumptions visibly separate	Evaluate, create	I
8	**Decide.** Generate at least three genuinely distinct options and appraise them against explicit criteria, including distributional effects and feasibility, to reach a justified recommendation	Evaluate	G
9	**Plan delivery.** Specify a theory of change, decision rights, responsibilities, risks and indicators for the recommended option	Create	H
10	**Communicate and defend.** Present the recommendation to a decision-making panel and respond to challenge without overstating the evidence	Evaluate	I, J

The cognitive levels follow the revised version of Bloom's taxonomy. They rise across the four weeks: Week 1 is mostly analysis, Week 3 adds evaluation of evidence, and Week 4 asks participants to evaluate options and create a plan. Domain J (professional judgement) runs through all ten outcomes rather than belonging to one.

4. Workbooks and artefacts referred to

The competency tables below name the artefact that shows each competency. They use the ten-workbook structure proposed in the Concept Note (P-17), which is not yet approved. If it changes, only the evidence column needs updating.

Workbook	Days	Main artefacts	Gate
WB1 Problem Framing	1 to 2	Problem sort; Problem Definition Canvas; Case Approval Form	
WB2 Structure and Causes	3 to 5	Issue tree; sealed working answer; problem tree; causal loop diagram	Gate 1, Day 5
WB3 Institutions and Actors	6 to 7	Delivery chain and funding map; stakeholder and incentive matrix	
WB4 Priorities, Hypotheses and Workplan	8 to 10	Pruning matrix; hypothesis register; workplan matrix	Gate 2, Day 10
WB5 Evidence	11 to 13	Data worksheet and charts; comparative case matrix; thematic notes	

Workbook	Days	Main artefacts	Gate
WB6 Testing and Synthesis	14 to 15	Hypothesis testing matrix; diagnostic memo	Gate 3, Day 15
WB7 Options and Choice	16 to 17	Journey map; options canvas; options appraisal	
WB8 Delivery Design	18	Theory of change; responsibility matrix; risk register	
WB9 Measurement and Pitch	19	Indicator framework; draft deck	Gate 4, Day 19
WB10 Capstone	20 and after	Presentation; client report; reflection	

Two artefacts run across workbooks: the **evidence register**, opened on Day 10, and the **Analyst's Ledger**, in which every substantive claim is tagged as fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis from Day 3 onwards.

Assessment components are abbreviated in the tables as follows.

Code	Component	Weight
WP	Workbook portfolio	35%
ER	Evidence register	15%
PP	Pod contribution and peer review	10%
CR	Client report	20%
PD	Presentation and defence (individual 15, pod synthesis 5)	20%

5. The competency framework

Each domain has a table of competencies and a three-level descriptor. The indicator column describes what an assessor sees at the **Working** level. The descriptors describe the whole domain at all three levels and are the basis for the Stage 8 rubrics.

Domain A. Problem framing

Outcome 1. Most weak policy analysis starts with a weak problem statement, and no amount of later rigour repairs it.

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
A1	Distinguishes problem, symptom, cause and solution	Sorts statements about the case into the four categories and rewrites any problem statement that contains a cause or a solution	1	WB1 problem sort	WP
A2	Frames the problem precisely	States the population, place, institution and period, the current and desired condition, and a measure of success that describes a change in what people can do or have	2	Problem Definition Canvas	WP (Gate 1), CR
A3	Bounds the scope	Lists at least two things deliberately left out, with reasons, and records at least two ways other actors would frame the problem, stating which framing the analysis adopts	1, 2	Canvas	WP
A4	Names the decision and the decision-making role	Identifies a role with the authority to act and a decision that role faces within a stated time, and explains why this role rather than another	1, 2, 6	Case Approval Form; canvas	WP, CR

Level	Descriptor
Foundational	The canvas is complete but the statement stays broad or contains a cause or solution. The decision-maker is "the government" in general
Working	The statement is specific, free of solutions and bounded. It names a role with authority and a real decision. Success is defined as a change in people's conditions
Advanced	Also anticipates how others would frame the problem, explains why the chosen framing serves the decision, and revises the framing when later evidence requires it

Domain B. Problem structuring

Outcome 2. Structure decides what gets analysed, and therefore what gets missed.

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
B1	Applies MECE	Branches at each level do not overlap and together cover the question. The participant can name the logic of each split, for example by stage of delivery, by actor, or by supply and demand	3	Issue tree	WP
B2	Builds an issue tree to three levels	By the third level, the tree reaches questions that available evidence could answer	3, 5	Issue tree, first and revised versions	WP (Gate 1)
B3	Writes a working answer early	Produces a hypothesis-led version of the tree and a sealed working answer of no more than 100 words	3	Sealed answer	CR (reflection)
B4	Prunes the tree	Rates branches by size of effect and ability to influence, drops low-priority branches with written reasons, and names the two or three branches the analysis will pursue	8	Pruning matrix	WP (Gate 2)

Level	Descriptor
Foundational	Branches overlap or leave out obvious categories. Levels mix questions with answers. The logic of the splits is unclear. Nothing is pruned
Working	MECE at every level, with the logic stated. Reaches answerable questions. Pruned with reasons
Advanced	Chooses the split that best serves the decision, uses a driver tree where the outcome can be broken down arithmetically, and restructures the tree as evidence arrives

Domain C. Causal and systems analysis

Outcome 3. A recommendation is only as good as the causal account behind it.

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
C1	Separates symptoms, proximate causes and structural causes	Builds a problem tree that places each element at the right level and states the mechanism behind each link	4	Problem tree	WP
C2	Uses root-cause tools with care	Uses Five Whys or a fishbone to generate candidate causes, then checks each against the problem tree instead of treating the chain as proof	4	WB2 worksheet	WP
C3	Represents feedback	Draws a causal loop diagram with at least one reinforcing or balancing loop that plausibly sustains the problem, with polarities marked	5	Causal loop diagram	WP (Gate 1)

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
C4	Anticipates unintended consequences	For the obvious fix, identifies at least two plausible unintended effects and the mechanism behind each	5, 16	Unintended consequences check	WP, PD
C5	Distinguishes correlation, causation and mechanism	Whenever an association is cited, states whether it supports a causal claim and why	4, 12, 14	Ledger; data worksheet	WP, ER

Level	Descriptor
Foundational	Lists causes without distinguishing levels. Treats one cause as the explanation. Draws arrows without mechanisms
Working	Distinguishes levels, states mechanisms, shows a sustaining loop and notes where causation is assumed rather than shown
Advanced	Weighs rival causal accounts, identifies the best- and worst-supported links, and uses the systems view to explain why earlier interventions failed

Domain D. Strategic and institutional analysis

Outcome 4. This is where the Lab differs most from a consulting course: the state is not a firm.

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
D1	Establishes jurisdiction	Identifies the list in the Seventh Schedule, or the Eleventh or Twelfth Schedule, that the subject falls under, and which body holds legislative authority, administrative control and funding	6	Delivery chain and funding map	WP
D2	Follows the money	Identifies the scheme or budget head that funds the activity, the cost-sharing arrangement and the most recent allocation, with source and year. State-level figures are acceptable where local figures are not published	6	Funding map; evidence register	WP, ER
D3	Maps the delivery chain	Maps each link from policy-maker to frontline worker to citizen, and marks the link where the evidence suggests delivery breaks down	6, 7	Delivery chain map	WP, CR
D4	Analyses actors and incentives	Builds a power-interest map that includes at least one group with high interest and little power or voice, and states the incentive and likely response of each key actor	7	Stakeholder and incentive matrix	WP, CR
D5	Uses context analysis selectively	Uses PESTLE as a check on the issue tree and adds only factors that would change the analysis	6	Completeness check	WP

Level	Descriptor
Foundational	Describes institutions in general terms. Lists stakeholders without incentives. Gives no account of funding
Working	Names the authority, the funding route and the delivery chain. Identifies incentives and absent voices. Locates the probable break point
Advanced	Explains how jurisdiction, money and incentives interact to produce the problem, and uses this to judge which options are feasible before appraising them

Domain E. Research and evidence

Outcome 6. All evidence is published or publicly available (Decision 5). The skill is finding it, judging it and combining it honestly.

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
E1	Turns hypotheses into a workplan	Links each priority hypothesis to an analysis, a named source and a deadline	10	Workplan matrix	WP (Gate 2)
E2	Locates credible Indian sources	For each priority hypothesis, finds and records at least one official dataset, one audit or parliamentary source, and one independent research source	10, 11	Evidence register	ER
E3	Judges reliability	Records for each source who produced it, how, when, its coverage and its known limitations, and gives a reliability rating with a reason	11	Evidence register	ER
E4	Analyses quantitative data	Produces three charts or tables that disaggregate or compare by place, group or time, each with year, source, interpretation and one limitation	12	Data worksheet	WP, ER
E5	Uses published qualitative and comparative evidence	Draws themes from published qualitative sources, such as social audit reports, CAG findings, committee testimony and field studies, and builds a comparative matrix of at least two other places that tackled a similar problem, noting the conditions for transfer	13	Comparative case matrix; thematic notes	WP
E6	Triangulates	For each main finding, cites at least two independent sources of different types, or states that only one exists	13, 14	Testing matrix; register	ER, CR

Level	Descriptor
Foundational	Relies on one source or on secondary summaries. Pays little attention to year, coverage or method. Charts lack sources
Working	Uses several types of source, rates reliability with reasons, disaggregates data, triangulates the main findings and states limitations
Advanced	Identifies where sources conflict and explains why, recognises measurement problems in administrative data, and adjusts confidence in findings accordingly

Domain F. Hypothesis-driven analysis

Outcome 5. The habit that separates analysis from advocacy is trying to prove yourself wrong.

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
F1	Formulates testable hypotheses	Writes three to five hypotheses, each specific enough that evidence could show it to be wrong	9	Hypothesis register	WP
F2	Specifies disconfirming evidence	For each hypothesis, states what evidence would weaken it and where that evidence might be found	9	Hypothesis register	WP (Gate 2)
F3	Considers rival explanations	For each priority hypothesis, names at least one competing explanation and what evidence would tell the two apart	9, 14	Register; testing matrix	WP, PD
F4	Separates fact, inference, assumption and hypothesis	Tags substantive claims in the Ledger correctly in at least nine of ten claims sampled at each gate	3 onwards	Analyst's Ledger	WP

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
F5	Updates beliefs on evidence	Records a verdict for each hypothesis (supported, weakened or unresolved) with the evidence, and explains in the reflection how the sealed answer changed	14, 20	Testing matrix; reflection	WP, CR

Level	Descriptor
Foundational	Hypotheses are vague or restate the problem. Looks only for confirming evidence. Claims are untagged or wrongly tagged
Working	Falsifiable hypotheses with disconfirming tests and rivals. Consistent tagging. Verdicts rest on evidence
Advanced	Designs the analysis to tell rivals apart efficiently, drops a favoured hypothesis when the evidence requires it, and traces the consequences for the recommendation

Domain G. Policy design and appraisal

Outcome 8. The eightfold path governs this domain: alternatives, criteria, projected outcomes, trade-offs, decision.

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
G1	Generates distinct options	Produces at least three options that differ in mechanism, not only in scale, plus a "do minimum" baseline. At least one changes an instrument and at least one adjusts settings	16	Options canvas	WP
G2	Designs from the citizen's experience	Uses a journey map of the affected group, built from published evidence, to show where each option acts, and states the How Might We question each option answers	16	Journey map	WP
G3	Appraises against explicit criteria	Builds an options matrix with stated criteria and weights, covering effectiveness, cost, administrative feasibility, political feasibility and distributional effect, with a reason for every score	17	Options appraisal	WP, CR
G4	Estimates cost per outcome and tests sensitivity	Gives a rough cost per unit of outcome for each option with assumptions stated, and shows whether the ranking changes under a plausible alternative assumption	17	Appraisal worksheet	WP, CR
G5	Applies the public value test	Tests the preferred option against public value, legitimacy and support, and operational capacity, states which is weakest and says how the plan deals with it	17	Appraisal; report	CR, PD

Level	Descriptor
Foundational	Options are versions of one idea or a wish list. Scores are unexplained numbers. Distribution is ignored
Working	Options are genuinely distinct. Criteria are explicit and include distribution. Scores are reasoned, sensitivity is checked and the recommendation follows from the appraisal
Advanced	Shows where the recommendation rests on a value judgement rather than evidence, designs a combined or sequenced option where that is better, and states what would change the choice

Domain H. Strategy execution

Outcome 9. A recommendation that ignores how it will be delivered is not finished.

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
H1	Builds a theory of change	Links activities, outputs, intermediate outcomes and final outcomes, and marks each causal link as evidenced or assumed	18	Theory of change	WP, CR
H2	Assigns decision rights and responsibilities	Uses RAPID for the key decisions or RACI for the main activities, with named roles rather than "the government", and leaves no activity without an accountable owner	18	Responsibility matrix	WP
H3	Chooses a delivery approach	States whether the option should be planned in full or built iteratively, with reasons tied to how predictable the context is and how much capability exists	18	Implementation plan	WP, CR
H4	Manages risk	Keeps a risk register of at least five risks spanning political, administrative, financial, frontline and distributional risk, each with likelihood, impact, owner and mitigation	18	Risk register	WP
H5	Designs indicators	Builds an indicator framework that separates inputs, outputs and outcomes, gives each indicator a source, baseline requirement and frequency, and includes at least one disaggregated indicator	19	Indicator framework	WP, CR

Level	Descriptor
Foundational	The plan lists activities and dates. The theory of change is a flowchart without assumptions. Indicators measure spending or activity only
Working	Theory of change with assumptions marked. Named owners. A reasoned delivery approach. A risk register. Output and outcome indicators with sources
Advanced	Links the riskiest assumptions to early indicators and decision points so that the plan can adapt, and anticipates how frontline workers will respond

Domain I. Professional communication

Outcomes 7 and 10. The decision-maker reads the first paragraph and the first slide. Everything else is support.

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
I1	Writes top-down	The memo opens with the governing message, every section supports it, the introduction follows SCQA, and it fits in two pages	15	Diagnostic memo	WP (Gate 3)
I2	Builds argument-led slides	Every slide title states a claim, the body supports it, and every data slide carries a source	15, 19	Deck	PD
I3	Visualises data honestly	Chart type suits the comparison; axes, year and source are shown; scales do not mislead	12	Charts	WP, ER
I4	Presents within time	Delivers the five-slide pitch in six minutes, with the recommendation in the first minute	19, 20	Presentation	PD
I5	Defends under questioning	Answers challenge directly, cites evidence, concedes uncertainty where appropriate and does not overstate	20	Defence	PD

Level	Descriptor
Foundational	Bottom-up: background first, conclusion last. Topic titles. Dense slides. Answers evade the question or overstate
Working	Governing message first. Claim titles. Clear charts with sources. On time. Direct answers that separate what is known from what is assumed
Advanced	Fits the message to the decision-maker's constraints, anticipates the strongest objection, and handles uncertainty in a way that adds to credibility

Domain J. Professional judgement

All outcomes. These are habits rather than techniques, and they are assessed through how the work changes over time.

ID	Competency	Indicator at the Working level	Day	Evidence	Assessed in
J1	Recognises the limits of tools	For each anchor tool used, states in one line what it could not show in the participant's own case	Throughout	Workbooks; tool cards	WP
J2	Makes trade-offs explicit	States what the recommendation gives up, and for whom	17, 20	Appraisal; report	CR, PD
J3	Avoids false precision	Rounds figures and gives ranges where appropriate; does not present scores or estimates as more certain than the evidence allows	12, 15, 17	Memo; report	WP, CR
J4	Acts on challenge	Revision notes and the pod log show at least one substantive change made in response to peer or instructor challenge at each gate	Gates	Revision notes; pod log	WP, PP
J5	Works with integrity	Uses only public sources, cites accurately, discloses AI assistance as required, and follows the working norms for sensitive cases	Throughout	Evidence register; AI disclosure	ER, all
J6	Strengthens others' work	Written peer reviews name a specific weakness and a specific improvement, and the participant carries out the pod role assigned each week	Weekly	Peer reviews; pod log	PP

Level	Descriptor
Foundational	Uses tools mechanically. Presents conclusions as certain. Revisions are cosmetic. Peer comments are generic
Working	Names tool limits, states trade-offs and uncertainty, revises substantively and gives specific peer feedback
Advanced	Declines to use a tool when it would mislead, raises ethical and distributional issues others missed, and improves the pod's work as well as their own

Count: A 4, B 4, C 5, D 5, E 6, F 5, G 5, H 5, I 5, J 6. Fifty competencies in all.

6. Day-by-day outcome map

Each session has one session outcome, written as what every participant has produced by the end of it. This is the line that will open each day's PPT blueprint and instructor notes.

Day	By the end of the session, each participant has...	Competencies	Output
1	sorted statements about their candidate cases into problem, symptom, cause and solution, and named a provisional decision-making role	A1, A3, A4	WB1 problem sort

Day	By the end of the session, each participant has...	Competencies	Output
2	completed the Problem Definition Canvas and submitted the Case Approval Form	A2, A3, A4	Canvas; Case Approval Form
3	built a three-level MECE issue tree, written and sealed a working answer, and begun the Analyst's Ledger	B1, B2, B3, F4	Issue tree; sealed answer
4	built a problem tree that separates symptoms from proximate and structural causes, and tested a Five Whys chain against it	C1, C2, C5	Problem tree
5	drawn a causal loop diagram, checked the obvious fix for unintended consequences, and submitted Gate 1	C3, C4, B2	Causal loop diagram; Gate 1
6	mapped the jurisdiction, funding route and delivery chain for their case, and run the PESTLE check	D1, D2, D3, D5	Delivery chain and funding map
7	built a power-interest and incentive matrix that includes absent voices	D3, D4	Stakeholder and incentive matrix
8	pruned the issue tree by size of effect and ability to influence	B4	Pruning matrix
9	written a hypothesis register with disconfirming evidence and rivals, and defended it in the Hypothesis Battle	F1, F2, F3	Hypothesis register
10	built a workplan, opened the evidence register and submitted Gate 2	E1, E2	Workplan; Gate 2
11	entered and rated at least six sources in the evidence register	E2, E3, J5	Evidence register
12	produced three charts that disaggregate or compare, each with interpretation and limitation	E4, I3, C5, J3	Data worksheet
13	built a comparative case matrix and drawn themes from published qualitative sources	E5, E6	Comparative matrix; thematic notes
14	recorded a verdict for each hypothesis and responded in writing to the red team	F3, F5, E6, J4	Testing matrix
15	written a two-page diagnostic memo and submitted Gate 3	I1, F4, J3	Diagnostic memo; Gate 3
16	generated at least three distinct options and a baseline from a journey map	G1, G2, C4	Journey map; options canvas
17	appraised the options, estimated cost per outcome, tested sensitivity and applied the public value test	G3, G4, G5, J2	Options appraisal
18	built a theory of change, responsibility matrix, delivery approach and risk register	H1, H2, H3, H4	Implementation plan
19	built an indicator framework, drafted the deck, rehearsed the five-slide pitch and submitted Gate 4	H5, I2, I4	Indicator framework; draft deck; Gate 4
20	presented, defended and contributed to the pod synthesis	I4, I5, J2	Presentation; report and reflection due 72 hours later

Every competency appears on at least one day. B3 and F5 close in the reflection, which opens the sealed answer.

7. Skill progression

Each domain moves through four stages: introduced (I), practised (P), given formative feedback at a gate (G), and assessed summatively (S).

Domain	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Capstone
A. Problem framing	I, P, G	P		P	S

Domain	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Capstone
B. Problem structuring	I, P, G	P, G			S
C. Causal and systems	I, P, G		P	P	S
D. Institutional		I, P, G	P	P	S
E. Research and evidence		I, G	P, G		S
F. Hypothesis-driven	I	P, G	P, G		S
G. Design and appraisal				I, P, G	S
H. Strategy execution				I, P, G	S
I. Communication			I, P, G	P, G	S
J. Judgement	I, P	P, G	P, G	P, G	S

Two observations. Domains A to F are introduced early and practised repeatedly, which is right: they are the foundation and the cohort's weakest area on entry. Domains G and H are introduced, practised and given feedback inside a single week, with only Gate 4 between first contact and the final assessment. Section 13 deals with this.

8. Assessment alignment

● marks the component where an outcome is mainly assessed; ○ marks a secondary component.

Outcome	WP	ER	PP	CR	PD	Individually assessed?
1 Frame	●			○	○	Yes
2 Structure	●			○		Yes
3 Diagnose	●			●		Yes
4 Situate	●	○		●		Yes
5 Hypothesise	●			○	○	Yes
6 Investigate	○	●		○		Yes
7 Synthesise	●			●		Yes
8 Decide	○			●	●	Yes
9 Plan delivery	○			●	○	Yes
10 Communicate and defend			○		●	Yes

Checks:

- Every outcome is assessed in at least two components.
- Every outcome is assessed individually. The only collective element is the 5 per cent pod synthesis within PD.
- Outcome 10 rests mainly on a single event, the Day 20 defence. That is acceptable for an oral skill, but the rubric must be reliable. Stage 8 should provide a structured question bank and a second assessor where possible.
- Diagnosis (Outcomes 1 to 7) is assessed mainly through the workbook portfolio and evidence register, which carry 50 per cent of the marks. Choice and delivery (Outcomes 8 and 9) are assessed mainly through the report and the presentation, which carry 40 per cent. The balance is reasonable, given that diagnosis takes three of the four weeks.

9. Cross-cutting professional skills and responsible AI

These skills are not taught in a separate module. They are practised through the case, and each has a standard and an artefact.

Skill	Where practised	Standard expected	Evidence
Spreadsheet analysis	Pre-course primer; Days 12 and 17	Sorting, filtering, a pivot table, a simple chart, formulas another person can follow	Data worksheet; cost-per-outcome sheet
Slide construction	Days 15 and 19	Claim titles, one message per slide, the Lab's visual template	Deck
Analytical writing	Days 2 and 15; report	Top-down memo and executive summary; plain English	Canvas; memo; report
Desk research and source management	Days 10 and 11	Register maintained; Chicago-style citations	Evidence register
Peer critique and teamwork	Weekly pod sessions	Rotating roles carried out; specific written reviews	Pod log; peer reviews
Time and project management	Day 10 workplan; gates	Gates submitted on time; workplan updated	Workplan; gate submissions
Responsible AI use	Throughout	See below	AI disclosure statement at each gate
Interviewing	Not taught	Removed by Decision 5	

Responsible AI use. Participants may use AI tools to suggest branches for an issue tree, propose rival hypotheses, critique a draft argument, find gaps in an analysis and improve the clarity of their writing. They may not use AI output as a source of facts, statistics, citations, legal provisions or descriptions of institutional responsibilities. Every such claim must be traced to a primary or authoritative source and recorded in the evidence register. Each gate submission carries a short disclosure statement describing any AI assistance. AI-generated evidence is not evidence.

10. Entry and exit diagnostic

Task. Read a two-page case brief. Write a problem statement of no more than 150 words. List the five questions you would most need answered. Suggest one thing the responsible official should do. Time: 45 minutes, completed at home before Day 1 and again in the final week.

Rubric. Four criteria, each scored 0 to 3, for a total out of 12.

Criterion	Linked to	0	1	2	3
Precision of the problem statement	A1, A2	Restates the topic	Names a problem but embeds a cause or solution, or is unbounded	Specific and free of solutions; partly bounded	Specific, bounded, focused on outcomes for people, and names who decides
Quality of questions	B1, F1	Generic	Relevant but overlapping or unordered	Distinct and covering the main areas	Structured, non-overlapping and prioritised
Awareness of evidence	E2, E3	None	Mentions "data" in general	Names plausible specific sources	Names sources and their limits

Criterion	Linked to	0	1	2	3
Actionability	A4, D1, G3	None, or a slogan	An action without an actor	An actor and an action	An actor, an action and a reason it is feasible, or the main risk

Design safeguards. Two case briefs of similar difficulty are used. Half the cohort gets Brief A at entry and Brief B at exit; the other half gets the reverse, so that a difference in difficulty between the briefs is not mistaken for progress. Scripts are anonymised and mixed before scoring, so the assessor does not know whether a script is from entry or exit. The cohort's average change is the programme's first real measure of whether it works.

11. Analyst Development Tracker

Feedback uses a short set of codes for recurring weaknesses. The tracker records which codes appear at each gate, so that by Gate 4 a participant can see which have cleared and which persist.

Code	Pattern	Domain
PF1	Solution or cause embedded in the problem statement	A
PF2	Scope too broad to analyse in four weeks	A
PF3	No decision-making role, or a role without authority	A, D
ST1	Overlapping or incomplete branches	B
ST2	No prioritisation: trying to analyse everything	B
CA1	Single-cause explanation	C
CA2	Correlation treated as causation	C, E
IN1	"The government" as the actor; no jurisdiction or funding route	D
IN2	Frontline workers or absent voices missing	D
EV1	One source, or one type of source	E
EV2	No year, coverage or limitation stated	E
EV3	Unverified figure or citation	E, J
HY1	Seeks only confirming evidence	F
HY2	Hypothesis cannot be tested	F
DE1	Jumps to a solution before the diagnosis is complete	G
DE2	Options are versions of one idea	G
DE3	Unexplained scores	G
EX1	Activity plan without causal logic	H
EX2	Indicators measure activity only	H
CO1	Conclusion buried	I
CO2	Topic titles instead of claims	I
CO3	Overstatement under questioning	I, J
JU1	Cosmetic revision	J

Instructor feedback at each gate follows the five headings set in the Concept Note (strongest element, critical weakness, missing dimension, required revision, next analytical task), and each heading cites a competency ID or tracker code where one applies. For example: "Critical weakness: CA2. Your district

comparison shows that attendance and learning levels move together, but not that one causes the other (C5)."

12. Completion standard (deferred)

Decision 4 is deferred to Stage 8. The indicators in Section 5 are written at the Working level so that any of these options can be applied later:

Option	Rule	Comment
(a)	Working level in all ten domains	Strictest; the certificate means the same thing for everyone
(b)	Working level in at least eight domains, including A, E, G and I	Allows for uneven profiles while protecting the core: framing, evidence, choice and communication
(c)	A marks threshold across the five components	Simplest to administer; a participant could pass with a serious gap in one domain

A distinction rule (for example, Advanced in at least six domains) can be added to any of the three.

13. Gap audit and next steps

13.1 Findings

Finding	Why it matters	Proposed fix
Domains G and H get only one formative check (Gate 4) before the summative assessment	Participants meet option appraisal and delivery design for the first time in the final week, and the report is the first place much of that work is marked	Add a pod-reviewed check of the options appraisal on Day 17, with one written comment from the instructor (P-19)
Fifty competencies are too many to score separately	Scoring each would make feedback slow and mechanical	Rubrics score the ten domains; competency IDs are used only to point feedback at the exact problem (P-18)
F4 sets a numerical standard (nine of ten claims)	It needs a sampling procedure or it will be applied inconsistently	Stage 8 defines how claims are sampled at each gate
E5 depends on published qualitative evidence, which is uneven across topics	Some cases may have almost nothing on how people experience the problem	Case Approval Form now requires one qualitative or field-based source (Concept Note 10.1)
D2 assumes funding data can be found	District and municipal budget data is often unpublished or hard to find	Indicator accepts state-level figures where local figures are not published
Quantitative skills stop at descriptive analysis	Participants cannot assess impact evaluations in depth	Deliberate. Stated in the calibrated promise; reading impact evaluations critically can be an Advanced extension
Outcome 10 rests mainly on one event	A single defence is a less reliable measure than repeated observation	Structured question bank; second assessor where possible (Stage 8)
No plain-language version for participants yet	Participants cannot self-assess against technical descriptors	Write it in Workbook 1 (Stage 6)

13.2 Items requiring verification

- The two references in the Annex.
- Whether "prune the tree" in Conn and McLean uses size of effect and ability to influence as its axes (carried over from Concept Note Annex B, item 1). B4 depends on it, although the competency stands on its own merit either way.

13.3 Decisions

Nothing here blocks Stage 3. Three small items are open for your approval when convenient: P-17 (ten workbooks), P-18 (domain-level rubrics) and P-19 (a check on Day 17).

13.4 Next stage

Stage 3: Framework research and library. The competency tables now fix which tools the course needs, about nineteen anchors and twenty supporting tools. Stage 3 researches each one at its source, verifies attribution, writes its tool card and records what it cannot do. It also widens the search beyond the firms already covered (PwC, KPMG, Accenture, government delivery units and development agencies) for tools that serve these competencies better than the current choices.

Annex. Sources and verification

Source (Chicago bibliography style)	Used for	Status
Anderson, Lorin W., and David R. Krathwohl, eds. *A Taxonomy for Learning, Teaching, and Assessing: A Revision of Bloom's Taxonomy of Educational Objectives*. New York: Longman, 2001.	Cognitive levels in Section 3	To verify
Biggs, John. "Enhancing Teaching through Constructive Alignment." *Higher Education* 32, no. 3 (1996): 347-64.	Constructive alignment in Section 1	To verify

All other works referred to here (Conn and McLean, Bardach and Patashnik, Moore, Sen, Lipsky, Hall) are listed with their verification status in Annex A of the Course Concept Note.